



WHAT AN EXTRAORDINARY STANCE!

LAGAAN / 2001

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Musical drama

DIRECTOR

Ashutosh Gowariker

WRITERS

K. P. Saxena (Hindi dialogue), Ashutosh Gowariker (English dialogue)

STARS

Aamir Khan, Gracy Singh, Rachel Shelley, Paul Blackthorne; narrated by Amitabh Bachchan

BEFORE

1957 Mehboob Khan's melodrama *Mother India* is the first Indian movie to be nominated for the Best Foreign Language Movie Oscar.

AFTER

2004 Gowariker's acclaimed follow-up to *Lagaan*, *Swades*, tells the story of a NASA scientist who returns to his native Indian village.

A story about a village cricket match in India under the British Raj in the 1890s, Ashutosh Gowariker's *Lagaan, Once Upon a Time in India* (to give it its full title) is one of the few Indian movies to have achieved audience and critical acclaim both within India and far beyond.

The scenario is a simple one. At a time when the remote village of Champaner in Gujarat is suffering from a drought, one of the villagers, Bhuvan (Aamir Khan), goes to the local British officer, Captain Andrew Russell (Paul Blackthorne), to plead for relief from the *lagan*, or crop tax. Russell dismisses his plea, but before Bhuvan leaves, he sees the British playing cricket and mocks the game. Incensed, Russell offers to cancel the villagers' taxes for three years if they can beat his men in a game—but if they lose, they will have to pay triple. To the horror of the villagers, Bhuvan accepts the challenge. The match occupies the entire second half of the movie, right up to the final, crucial ball.

Crowd-pleasing story

Lagaan's success at the box office was partly due to its sheer entertainment value. It is a stirring,

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The movie is not just a story.

It is an experience. An experience of watching something that puts life into you, that puts a cheer on your face, however depressed you might be.

Sudish Kamath

The Hindu

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old-fashioned adventure in which plucky underdogs get together to take on the bullies, and it has everything you'd expect from such a classic story. There is a romantic triangle, as Captain Russell's sister Elizabeth (Rachel Shelley) falls for Bhuvan, who is already pledged to local girl Gauri (Gracy Singh). There is a jealous lover, Lakha, who, spurned by Gauri, helps the British. There are comic characters galore, and even the poor outsider who turns out to be a hero.